

Northwind Orchards

Harvest Report, Third Quarter

Rain arrived late in the valley this year, and the trees answered the way they always do when the ground stays wet into June: heavy fruit on the lower branches and almost nothing above the reach of a short ladder. The pickers finished the eastern blocks a full week behind schedule and made none of it back on the western slope, where the fog sat until midmorning most days and the crews could not start until the leaves had dried.

The cider press ran a second shift through most of August. That was not planned, but the windfall from the storm on the eleventh was too large to sort by hand and too bruised to sell whole, so it went to the press instead of the packing house. The result reads oddly in the figures below: a poor season by weight, and the best cider yield the orchard has recorded.

Block	Trees	Tonnes	Yield per tree	To press
Eastern	840	47.2	56.2kg	18%
Western	610	22.9	37.5kg	41%
Riverbank	295	19.4	65.8kg	9%
Nursery	150	3.1	20.7kg	0%

Riverbank remains the puzzle. It carries the fewest trees of any mature block and returns the most fruit from each of them, on ground the survey still lists as marginal. The agronomist has been asked twice for an explanation and has twice suggested drainage, which is almost certainly correct and almost certainly incomplete.

Two decisions follow from the season. The nursery block will not be picked commercially again until the fourth year, since three tonnes does not pay for the labour to gather it. And the western slope will be thinned over the winter, hard, on the theory that fewer trees standing further apart will dry sooner in the morning and give the crews back the week they lost.